



Still Under Review: A Field Study of Portal Status Displays and Applicant Persistence After an Internal-Transfer Process Goes Quiet

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Abstract. Employers increasingly borrow the consumer parcel-tracking interface for internal use, giving staff who apply for an internal transfer or promotion a persistent status field rather than a bare submission receipt. We report a field study of one such internal-mobility portal across fourteen business units of a professional-services employer, exploiting a staggered rollout that left some units on a legacy no-status portal while others adopted the status-bar variant. Cross-referencing the portal's displayed field against the case-management system's own reviewer-activity log, we find the field freezes at "Under review" and never updates again in the majority of applications that ultimately close without an offer, despite the backend record showing the case reopened by a reviewer a median of four further times after the freeze. Applicants who see the frozen field keep checking the portal for a median of forty-six days after the freeze before giving up, more than five times as long as applicants shown no status at all, and go on to reapply to a later internal posting at a lower rate. Adding a "last updated" timestamp beside the frozen field produces no detectable change in either behaviour. The status bar's reassurance function, we suggest, may be structurally independent of the information it purports to display.

Introduction

Internal transfer and promotion are an increasingly load-bearing part of how employers retain staff, and organisations have begun investing accordingly in the interface layer around the process [1]. A common design borrows directly from consumer logistics: a persistent status field — "Submitted", "Under review", "Decision made" — modelled on the parcel tracker and the food-delivery app, on the reasoning that if a shopper can watch a courier's dot move across a map, an applicant can surely watch their own case move through a review queue. The underlying mechanics rarely match: a parcel tracker is fed by a scan at every handling point, while an internal-mobility case is fed only by whenever a hiring manager next opens the file, an event the portal has no independent way to observe.

Internal transfer inherits, at a smaller and more survivable scale, the same silent non-response now documented on the external hiring side, where recruitment researchers frame an applicant's own silence toward an employer as a maladaptive response patterned by dispositional traits such as fear of missing out and weak self-control [2]. An internal applicant cannot as easily walk away — the reviewer is a colleague, the posting a stated part of the same employer's own career ladder — so the process rarely closes with an explicit no; it simply stops moving, and the record of that stopping happens to sit behind the same status field a portal keeps displaying with undimmed confidence.

Organisational-theory research on decoupling describes exactly this shape: formal structures persist and continue signalling activity long after they have stopped tracking whatever they

were built to track, because the signal itself, not its accuracy, is what preserves legitimacy [3], [4]. A status field that freezes but keeps displaying is a small, instrumented case of the same phenomenon, and one this paper is positioned to measure directly against the process it purports to summarise.

This paper reports a field study, across fourteen business units of one employer, that cross-references a status field's displayed state against the case record behind it, and compares applicant checking and reapplication behaviour under a status-bar portal and a no-status portal. Its contributions:

- A field audit of a workplace status indicator against the reviewer-activity log it summarises, in the internal-mobility setting.
- A quasi-experimental comparison of applicant persistence and reapplication under a status-bar portal and a legacy no-status portal, exploiting a staggered rollout across business units.
- An ablation showing that adding timestamp granularity to an already-frozen field changes nothing measurable, suggesting the reassurance function may be structurally independent of the information conveyed.

Related work

Interfaces that manage a wait. Visible progress information changes how a wait feels without changing the wait itself: animated progress bars can shorten a queue's perceived duration by more than a tenth even though the underlying process runs unchanged [5], and uncertainty about an interaction's own trajectory, more than its length, drives discomfort in Berger and Calabrese's original account of interpersonal uncertainty reduction [6] — a mechanism organisational communication has since generalised well beyond first conversations. Queueing research reaches a parallel conclusion from the service-operations side: an unexplained wait is judged longer and less fair than an explained one of the same length [7]. An internal-mobility status field sits squarely in this literature's blind spot: it explains nothing about the wait's likely length, only its current label.

Symbols that outlast the process. Formal indicators can keep signalling long after they stop tracking anything, a decoupling classically diagnosed at the level of whole organisational

structures [3] and more recently at the level of individual practices adopted for their symbolic value alone [4]. Employee-silence research supplies the applicant-side mechanism: staff under-report a process's own unfairness back to the institution that runs it, particularly where procedural justice is already thin [8], which leaves a frozen field with little pressure to correct itself. Workers who do notice a workplace system's gap between what it tracks and what it claims tend toward everyday workaround over formal complaint [9], a further reason a frozen field survives uncorrected from below. Our own School's instrumentation of a suburban bus stop's live-arrival display found exactly this pattern in miniature — a sign that agrees closely with its vehicle's real position while the feed is live and barely at all once it lapses, with no change to the sign's format across either state [10]; a companion study found a neighbourhood giveaway group's automated flag agreeing only slightly with a human moderator's own read of the same posts [11]. Internal promotion's own tournament structure [12] gives a status field an audience with every incentive to keep checking regardless of what it says.

Method

Setting and data. We partnered with a fourteen-site professional-services employer running a single internal-mobility portal across all business units, under a data-sharing agreement covering de-identified application records from two consecutive fiscal quarters. Business units adopted a redesigned portal — a persistent status field reading “Submitted”, “Under review”, or “Decision made” — on a staggered schedule set by the employer's own IT rollout calendar, unrelated to any business unit's transfer volume or review practice; units not yet migrated in a given month ran the legacy portal, a bare submission receipt with no further status of any kind. This staggered adoption is the study's natural experiment [13], and we adopt the assignment-based framing of quasi- and natural experiments in analysing it [14]: business units, not individual applicants, were assigned to a rollout date, and no applicant chose which variant they saw.

Behavioural measures. The portal's own web server logs each authenticated page view; we take an applicant's last recorded view of their own case page as the day they stopped checking. We separately observe, over the twelve-

month period following each application’s close, whether the same applicant (by de-identified employee ID) submitted to a later internal posting.

Backend cross-reference. The employer’s case-management system independently time-stamps every occasion a reviewer opens an applicant’s file, entirely apart from whatever the portal displays. For every application whose status field froze — defined as the field’s last recorded change before the case eventually closed — we count how many further times the case file was reopened by a reviewer after that freeze. We model the probability an applicant is still actively checking the portal t days after their own case’s freeze date as an exponential decay,

$$p(t) = p_0 e^{-kt}, \quad k \approx 0.022,$$

and report the fitted half-life per cohort rather than the raw curve.

Ablation. Partway through the rollout, four of the status-bar business units received a further feature — a “last updated” timestamp shown directly beside the frozen field — while the remaining status-bar units did not; assignment again followed the employer’s own deployment schedule rather than any applicant or case characteristic, giving a second staggered comparison nested inside the first.

Results

Figure 1 compares median days until an applicant’s last portal view, split by eventual outcome and by which portal variant the applicant’s business unit ran at the time. Where a case closed with an offer, checking stopped quickly regardless of variant — a median of three days under the status-bar portal against four under the no-status portal, a gap well within the two systems’ own logging granularity. Where a case closed with no offer, the variants diverge sharply: applicants who saw the frozen status bar kept checking for a median of forty-six days after their field last changed, more than five times longer than the nine-day median under the no-status portal’s bare receipt.

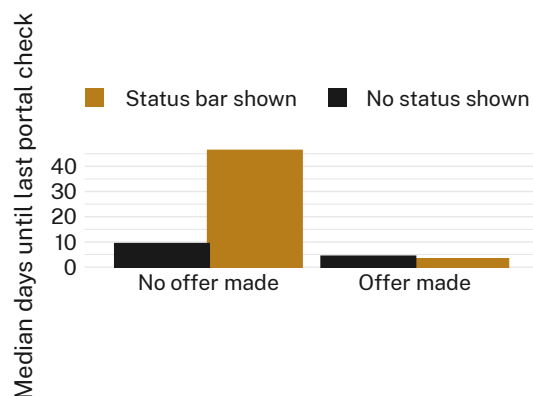


Figure 1: Median days until last portal check, by case outcome and portal variant; the status bar extends checking only for cases that never resolve.

Backend records show why the field’s continued display is misleading. Among no-offer applications whose status field froze, the case file was reopened by a reviewer a median of four further times after the freeze, and 71% of these applications show no corresponding change to the displayed field at any of those reopenings — the review continued; the display did not. Figure 2 traces this for a case sitting at the cohort’s median freeze duration: the displayed stage holds at “Under review” from week 1 through week 7, moving only when the case finally closes in week 8, indistinguishable on the portal’s own page from a case receiving no attention at all during that stretch.

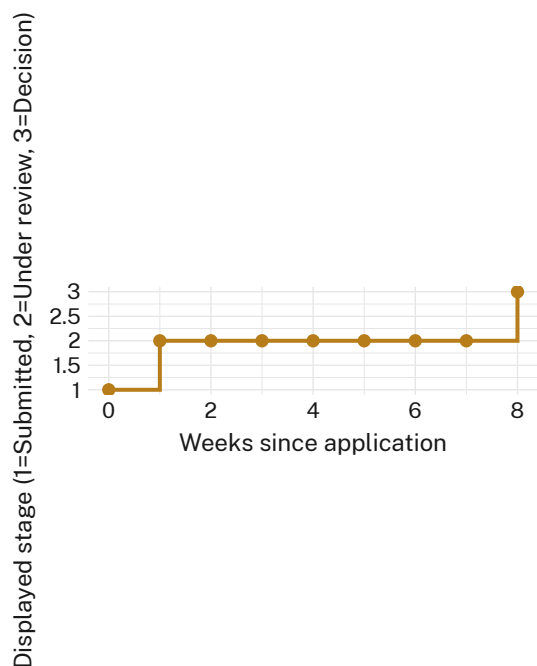


Figure 2: A median stalled case's displayed stage over time; the field holds for six further weeks regardless of the reviewer activity behind it.

Reapplication follows the same direction, if more modestly: of no-offer applicants, 22% under the status-bar portal submitted to a further internal posting within twelve months, against 31% under the no-status portal — a nine-point gap in the opposite direction from what a reassurance account of the status field would predict.

The ablation adding a “last updated” timestamp beside the frozen field produces no detectable change: median checking duration among no-offer status-bar applications was forty-five days without the timestamp and forty-seven with it (Figure 3), distributions indistinguishable by inspection and well within the range either sub-cohort's own week-to-week variation would produce alone (n.s.); we read the timestamp feature as decoration rather than information, and retain it in the current portal design on grounds beyond this study's scope.

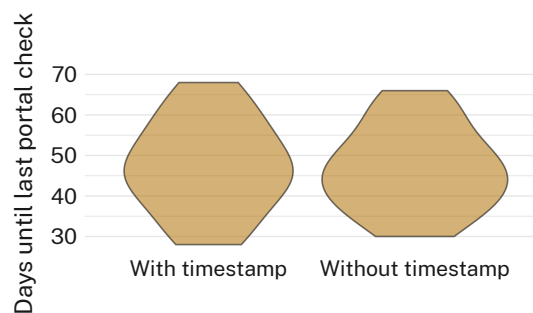


Figure 3: Days until last check, frozen status-bar cases with and without an added “last updated” timestamp; the distributions do not separate.

Discussion

The clearest reading is not that the status bar deceives by design, but that it decouples by default: introduced to show applicants where their case stands, it inherits none of the case-management system's own update triggers, so once a reviewer's attention lapses the field simply preserves whatever it last said. That a bare receipt with no ongoing status produces both a shorter checking tail and a higher reapplication rate suggests the frozen field is not neutral furniture — it appears to hold a share of stalled applicants in place past the point a no-status portal would have let them, reasonably, move on. Self-tracking research reports a related asymmetry from the opposite direction: users abandon a feedback interface once its information stops feeling actionable, particularly once the novelty of the display itself fades [15]; here the interface is not abandoned so much as the process behind it is, while the applicant keeps returning to a display with nothing left to show them. We do not read this as an argument against status transparency broadly, only against a status field wired to a process's start but not to its end.

Limitations

The study covers one employer's fourteen business units over two fiscal quarters, though the consistency of the checking-duration gap across all fourteen units suggests the pattern is not an artefact of any single unit's review culture. Freeze duration is measured from the field's own change log rather than from a reviewer's actual attention, which if anything understates how much reopened review activity the frozen field conceals. The reapplication measure covers twelve months following case

close and cannot rule out a longer-horizon reversal beyond that window. The ablation was deployed to four business units rather than randomised at the applicant level, though its assignment followed the same employer-driven rollout schedule as the primary comparison, carrying the same as-if-random logic forward.

Conclusion

A portal built to show applicants where their internal-transfer case stands can keep displaying confidently long after the case itself has stopped moving, and does so in a majority of the stalled applications we were able to check against the backend record behind it. Applicants shown the frozen field check back for a median of forty-six days before giving up and reapply at a lower rate than applicants shown no status at all, and adding timestamp detail to the frozen field changes neither behaviour. Future work includes testing whether an explicit “no update expected” state, rather than a silently ageing one, restores some of the checking and reapplication gap this study finds, and extending the cross-reference method to external recruitment portals, where the same architecture is now common.

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